Where Football Clubs Come From

Founding years of 45,931 association football clubs in Wikidata, from Sheffield FC in 1857 to today

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Abstract

Association football spread from a handful of clubs in northern England in the 1850s and 1860s to almost every country on earth. I use Wikidata, the open knowledge base behind Wikipedia, to map that spread from the bottom up: every item that is an association football club, with its founding year, its dissolution year and a location. After removing national teams, reserve and youth sides, beach soccer and futsal teams and probable Australian rules clubs, 45,931 clubs remain, 27,079 (59%) with a founding year and 16,227 (35%) with a point. The oldest dated club Wikidata records in each of 222 countries and territories traces a diffusion front: 55 had a club before 1900 and 173 before 1950, and first clubs founded before 1900 lie a median 1,966 km from Sheffield against 6,894 km for those founded after 1950. Before 1900, 93% of new clubs were European and 59% were in the United Kingdom; the busiest year is 1919 (475 clubs), Europe's busiest decade the 1920s, and every other continent's the 2000s. Wikidata records 4,091 dissolutions, peaking in 1945 (174 clubs, 143 of them German). Coverage is very uneven: the Netherlands has 165 clubs per million people in Wikidata and Nigeria 0.6. The atlas maps what the open record says about where clubs come from, and is explicit about what it cannot say, including who founded them.

Keywords: football; soccer; association football clubs; diffusion; sport history; Wikidata; open data; mapping

1 Introduction

Sheffield FC, founded in 1857, is usually called the oldest football club in the world, and the game that the Football Association codified in London in 1863 spread with remarkable speed. Historians have told that story through rules, associations and individual pioneers: public school and working-class football in England (Harvey, 2005), and the global spread carried by trade, empire, migration and education (Goldblatt, 2006; Giulianotti and Robertson, 2004). What is harder to see is the aggregate pattern, the thousands of clubs founded decade after decade, country after country.

Wikidata (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) offers a way to look at that pattern from the bottom up. It is an open, structured database of named things, including tens of thousands of football clubs, many with a founding date, a location or a home ground, and some with a dissolution date. It is also uneven, catalogued by volunteers with very different interests in different countries. This paper uses it to ask three simple questions: when did each country get its first (recorded) club, how did club founding rise and fall by decade and continent, and which clubs did not survive? It pairs the analysis with an interactive, animated atlas (https://maps.tristanhotham.com/football-origins/).

The contribution is descriptive and deliberately modest. Wikidata is not a census of clubs, and a

Table 1: From query to data.

Step	Items
Rows returned by the query	48,286
Distinct Wikidata items	46,993
Left out: national teams, beach and futsal, reserve and youth teams, Australian rules clubs	1,062
Clubs kept	45,931
with a founding year	27,079
of which from 1857 (used for the timeline)	27,059
with a point (own 3,004; ground 10,046; town in name 3,177)	16,227
with a founding year from 1857 and a point (on the animated map)	12,589
with a present-day country	42,032
with a dissolution year	4,097

founding year in Wikidata is not proof of when football was first played anywhere. I am explicit throughout about coverage, and about one question the data cannot answer: who founded these clubs. Wikidata does not record the nationality of founders, so nothing here measures the part played by British workers, sailors, engineers or students abroad, however prominent it is in the literature.

2 Data

Wikidata. A single query through the QLever SPARQL endpoint (Bast and Buchhold, 2017), retrieved in 2026, returned every item that is an instance of association football club (Q476028) or of one of its subclasses, with its English label, inception (P571), dissolution (P576), coordinates (P625), the coordinates of its home venue (P115), country (P17), number of sitelinks and class. Because each combination of these values is a row, the result has 48,286 rows for 46,993 items. Wikidata is published under CC0.

Geography. Natural Earth (Natural Earth, 2026) countries (1:50m for display, 1:10m for point in polygon), states and provinces (to split the United Kingdom into England, Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland, each of which has its own football association), populated places (for clubs whose name contains a town) and population estimates. All are public domain.

Check. The engsoccerdata club table (Curley, 2016) gives coordinates for 465 English clubs that match Wikidata labels; 451 of them lie within 10 km of the Wikidata point. The two sources are probably not independent (both draw on Wikipedia), so this checks transcription rather than truth.

3 Methods

3.1 Which items are clubs

I kept one record per item and pooled values across rows. I left out 1,062 items that are not clubs in the usual sense: 377 national and representative teams (by class or by names such as 'national football team'), 88 beach soccer and futsal sides, 428 reserve, B, II and under-age teams (which repeat the founding year of their parent club), and 169 Australian clubs whose names (a spelt-out

'Football Club', 'Football Netball Club' or 'Australian Football Club' with no soccer word) mark them as Australian rules football clubs, a class Wikidata often confuses with association football. These filters are name based and imperfect in both directions.

3.2 Dates

The founding year is the earliest inception year of an item; 86% of founding dates are stored as 1 January, which in Wikidata usually means that only the year is known, so I work in years throughout. 20 clubs have a founding year before 1857. On inspection these are cricket, rowing, gymnastics and multi-sport societies older than the football they later took up, plus a few errors (a Spanish club dated 1492, an Ecuadorian club dated a century early); they are kept in the data with a flag but left out of the timeline and the first-club analysis. One founding year in the future (1 club) was removed. The dissolution year is the latest P576 year; 6 clubs with a dissolution before their founding are flagged and left out of the dissolution counts.

3.3 Places and countries

A club's point is its own coordinates (3,004 clubs), else its home venue's (10,046), else, if its English label contains the name of a Natural Earth populated place in the same country (excluding common words such as Union, Victoria or Santa), that place (3,177). The last is approximate and is flagged. A club's country is the present-day country (or UK nation) that its point falls in, else the country Wikidata gives, matched to Natural Earth by Wikidata identifier. Where both are known they agree for 98% of 12,796 clubs. 457 clubs whose only country is a former state (the Soviet Union, the German Reich, Czechoslovakia, Austria-Hungary, Yugoslavia) and that have no point are kept in the totals but given no present-day country, and 1,489 UK clubs with no point stay as 'United Kingdom'. Continents follow Natural Earth, with small island states assigned to their nearest continent.

3.4 First clubs and the diffusion front

For each country I take the oldest club with a founding year from 1857 (ties broken by sitelinks), and measure the great-circle distance from Sheffield to its point (or to the country's label point if it has none). I use this as a simple, transparent diffusion front, not as a model of diffusion: it tells us when a club that still has a Wikidata entry was founded, which may be long after football was first played, and in multi-sport societies may be long before.

4 Results

4.1 The spread

Figure 1 shows every dated club with a point at six moments. In 1870, 61% of the 84 clubs in the record are in the United Kingdom, with outliers in a handful of other countries, several of them older sports societies; by 1890 they cover the British Isles densely and are scattered through the ports and cities of western Europe, the River Plate, India, southern Africa and Australia; by 1930 they cover Europe and much of South America; after 1960 they reach almost everywhere. By 2026 the record holds 222 countries and territories with a dated club.

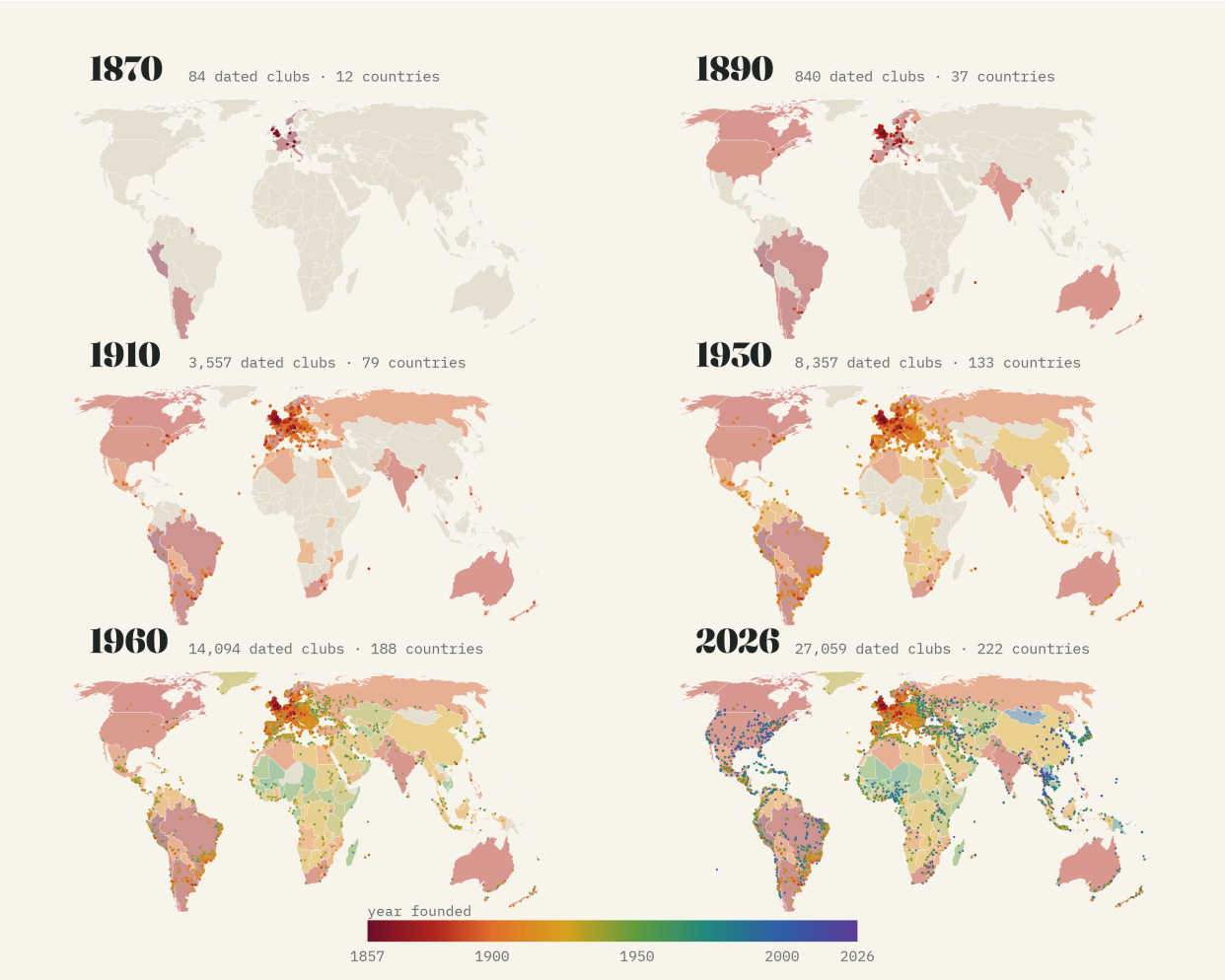


Figure 1: Clubs with a founding year and a point, by year founded, at six moments. Countries are shaded once they have a dated club.

4.2 First clubs

Figure 2 maps the year of each country's oldest dated club, and Figure 3 plots it against distance from Sheffield. The pattern is a front that moves outwards but leaps by sea. Countries whose first club came before 1900 sit a median 1,966 km from Sheffield, those after 1950 a median 6,894 km, and the correlation between year and distance is a modest 0.36. Peru (the Lima Cricket and Football Club, 1859), Argentina, Uruguay, India and Australia all have clubs in the record before Hungary, Poland or Russia. Table 2 summarises by continent and Table 3 lists the earliest first clubs.

Many first clubs are multi-sport societies. Switzerland's is the Lausanne Football and Cricket Club (1860), Uruguay's the Montevideo Rowing Club (1874), Norway's a gymnastics society in Drammen (1857), Italy's the Bentegodi gymnastics society in Verona (1868). Wikidata records the founding of the whole club, so these dates say when a club that now has a football side was founded. Others are surprising and may be wrong: France's oldest dated club, a club in Cergy-Pontoise, is given 1865.

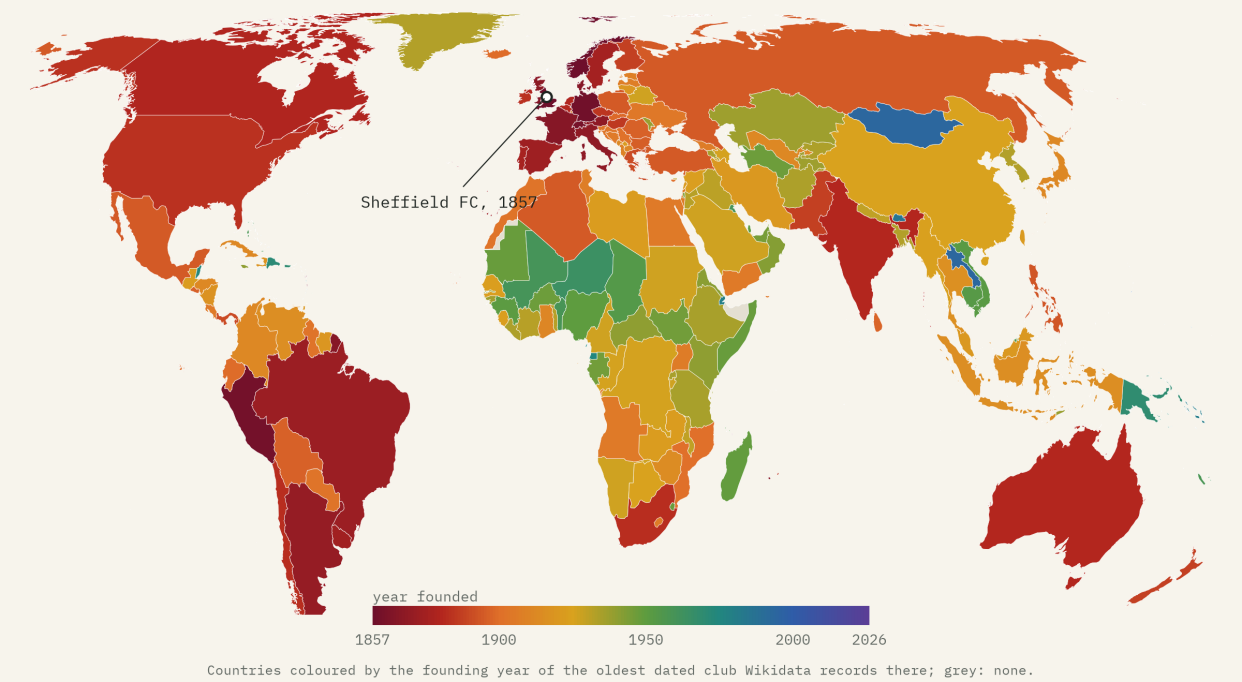


Figure 2: Year of the oldest dated club in Wikidata, by country.

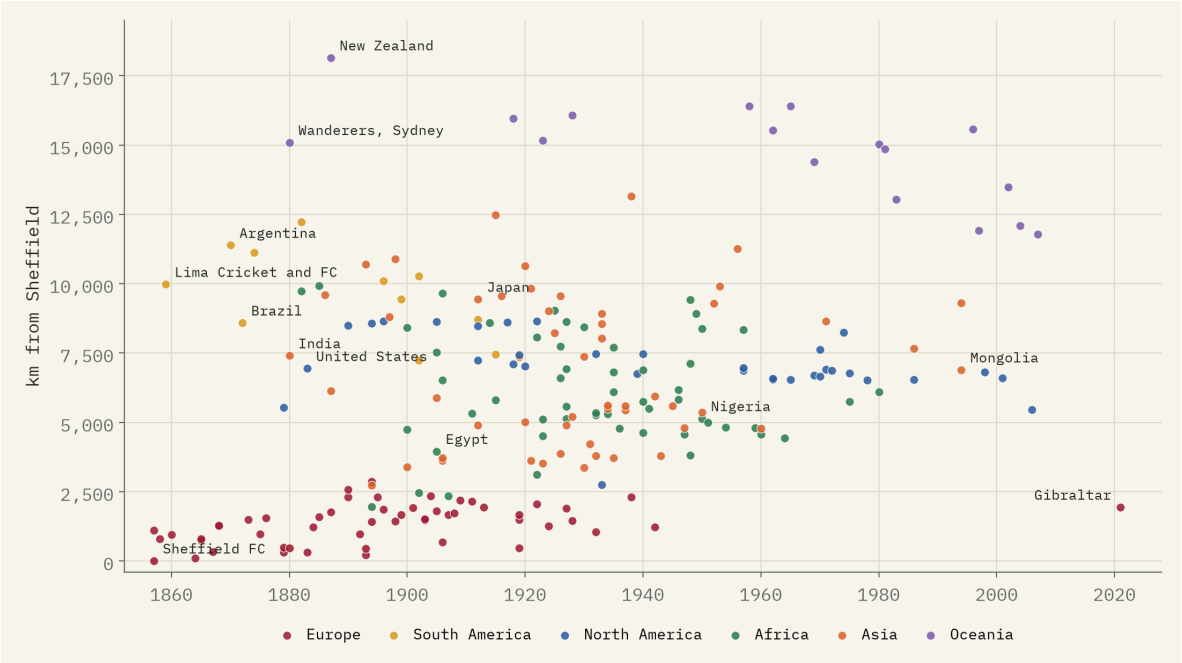


Figure 3: The diffusion front: year of each country's oldest dated club against the distance of that club from Sheffield.

Table 2: First clubs by continent: number of countries and territories with a dated club, the earliest, and the median year of countries' first clubs.

Continent	Countries	Earliest	Club	Year	Median
Europe	53	England	Sheffield F.C.	1857	1894
South America	12	Peru	Lima Cricket and Football Club	1859	1898
North America	34	Canada	Toronto Varsity Blues men's soccer	1879	1948
Africa	54	South Africa	Savages FC Pietermaritzburg	1882	1932
Asia	52	India	Dalhousie AC	1880	1929
Oceania	17	Australia	Wanderers F.C.	1880	1969

Table 3: The earliest first clubs: the oldest dated club Wikidata records in each country or territory, first 36 (all are in data/first_clubs.csv).

Year	Country	Club	km from Sheffield
1857	England	Sheffield F.C.	3
1857	Norway	Drammens TF	1,108
1858	Germany	SV 1858 Alfeld/Leine	805
1859	Peru	Lima Cricket and Football Club	9,977
1860	Switzerland	Lausanne Football and Cricket Club	957
1864	Wales	Wrexham A.F.C.	109
1865	Denmark	Skamby Boldklub	732
1865	France	Cergy Pontoise FC	796
1867	Scotland	Queen's Park F.C.	326
1868	Italy	Bentegodi Verona	1,258
1868	Austria	(no English label) Q63306374	1,278
1870	Argentina	Club Atlético Carcarañá	11,387
1872	Brazil	Paissandu Atlético Clube	8,586
1873	Spain	Exiles Cable Club	1,486
1874	Uruguay	Montevideo Rowing Club	11,134
1875	Sweden	Göteborgs BK	970
1876	Portugal	Associação Académica de Coimbra, O.A.F.	1,556
1879	Northern Ireland	Cliftonville F.C.	324
1879	Netherlands	Koninklijke HFC	486
1879	Canada	Toronto Varsity Blues men's soccer	5,545
1880	Belgium	Royal Antwerp F.C.	469
1880	India	Dalhousie AC	7,404
1880	Australia	Wanderers F.C.	15,096
1882	South Africa	Savages FC Pietermaritzburg	9,728
1882	Chile	(no English label) Q5988624	12,231
1883	Ireland	Dublin University Association Football Club	318
1883	United States	Clark O.N.T.	6,942
1884	Czech Republic	FK Jiskra Třeboň	1,223
1885	Hungary	Újpest FC	1,584
1885	Mauritius	Arsenal Wanderers	9,928
1886	Hong Kong	HKFC Soccer Section	9,591
1887	Finland	Helsingin Ponnistus	1,761
1887	Pakistan	KPT F.C.	6,137
1887	New Zealand	North Shore United AFC	18,148
1890	Malta	St. George's F.C.	2,304
1890	Greece	Panionios F.C.	2,578

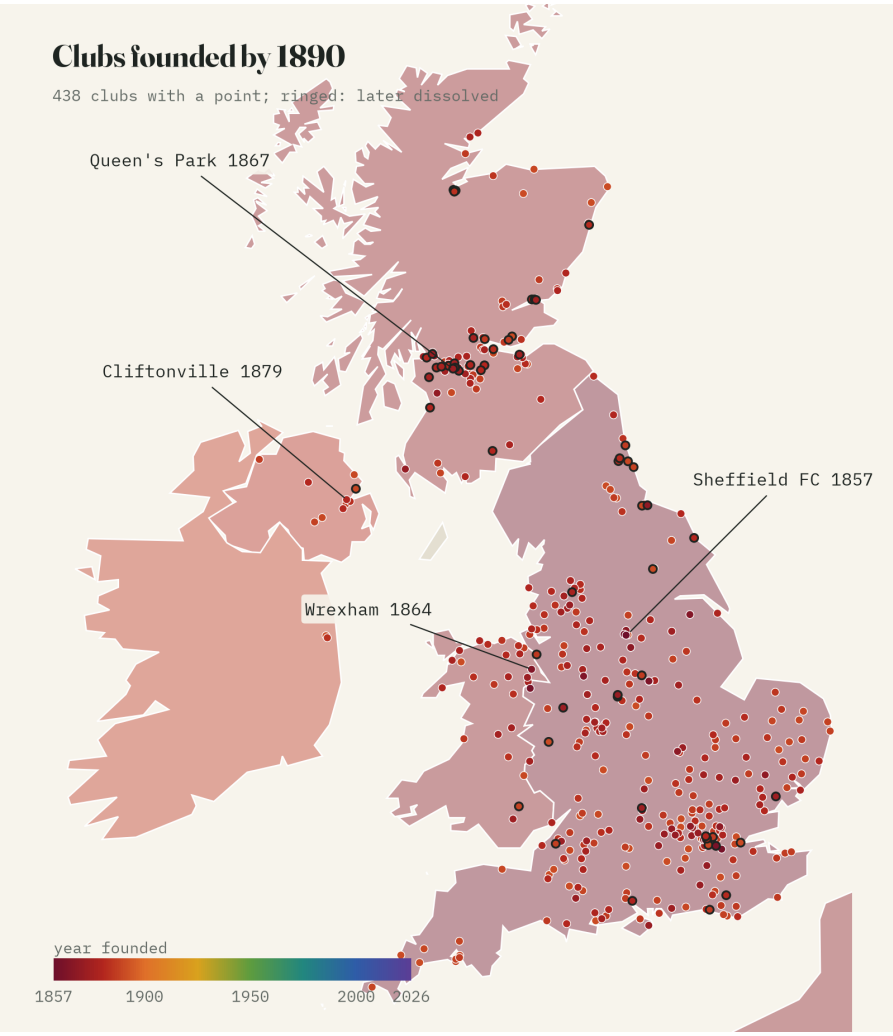


Figure 4: Clubs in the British Isles founded by 1890, by year founded. Ringed: later dissolved.

4.3 The British Isles

Of the 314 clubs dated before 1880, 258 are in the United Kingdom (Figure 4). The first club in each nation is Sheffield FC in England (1857), Wrexham in Wales (1864), Queen's Park in Scotland (1867) and Cliftonville in Northern Ireland (1879). England's early list includes Hallam (1860), Notts County (1862), Stoke (1863), Nottingham Forest (1865) and Sheffield Wednesday (1867), and London clubs of the early FA Cup, such as the Wanderers, that no longer exist.

4.4 Founding waves

Figure 5 shows clubs founded per decade by continent. Europe dominates the early record (93% of clubs founded before 1900 and 79% from 1900 to 1949) and peaks in the 1920s; the single busiest year is 1919 (475 clubs), as the First World War ended. Every other continent peaks in the 2000s, and since 2000 Europe's share of new clubs falls to 38%, with Asia at 26% and North America at 17%. Clubs founded since 1990 make up 29% of dated clubs. Part of the recent rise is real (new professional leagues, independent states, women's football) and part reflects recording: recent clubs are more likely to have a founding date and an entry at all.

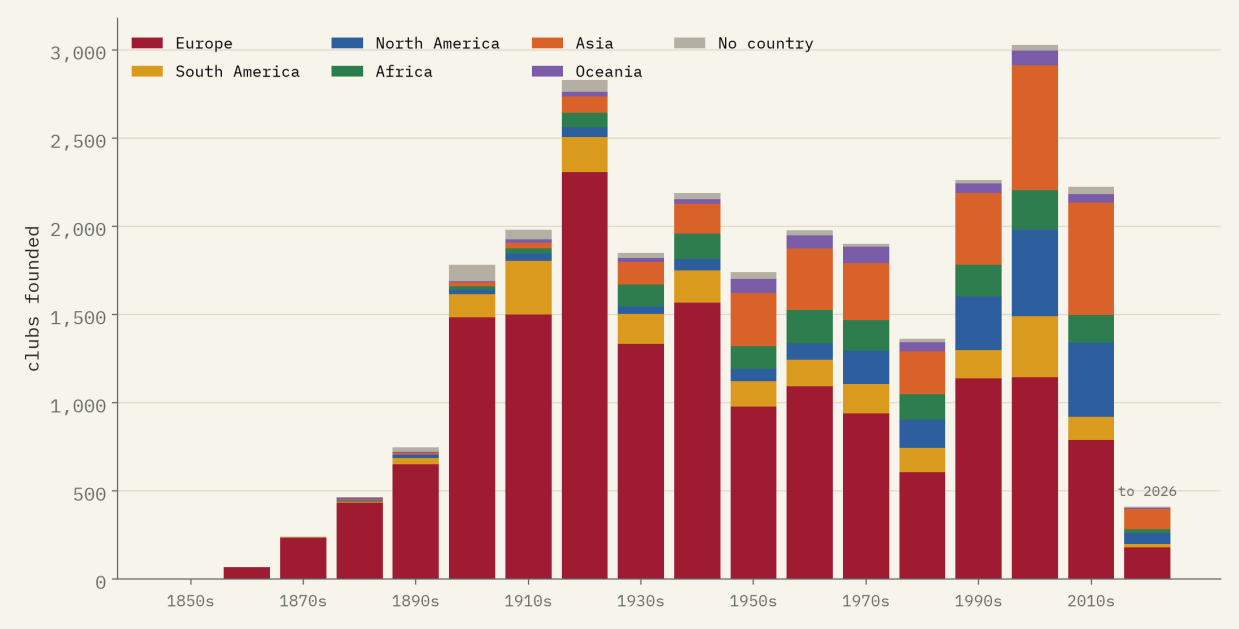


Figure 5: Clubs founded per decade, by continent (27,059 clubs with a founding year from 1857). The 2020s run to 2026.

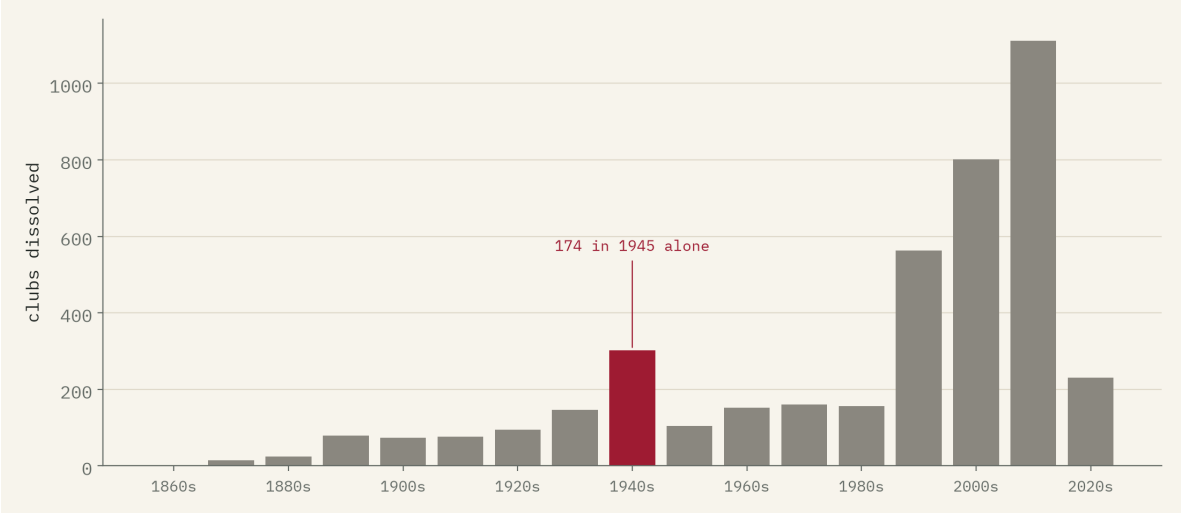


Figure 6: Clubs dissolved per decade (P576).

4.5 Clubs that died

Wikidata records a dissolution for 4,091 clubs (9%), shown by decade in Figure 6. The single worst year is 1945: 174 clubs, 143 of them in Germany or with the German Reich as their country, when the Allied Control Council dissolved German sports organisations and clubs in the lost eastern territories ceased to exist. Since 2000 there have been 2,144 recorded dissolutions (52% of the total), a mixture of real closures, mergers and refoundings and of easier recording. Among clubs with both dates the median lifespan is 23 years, and 791 lasted five years or fewer. The oldest club recorded as dissolved is the Wanderers (1859 to 1887).

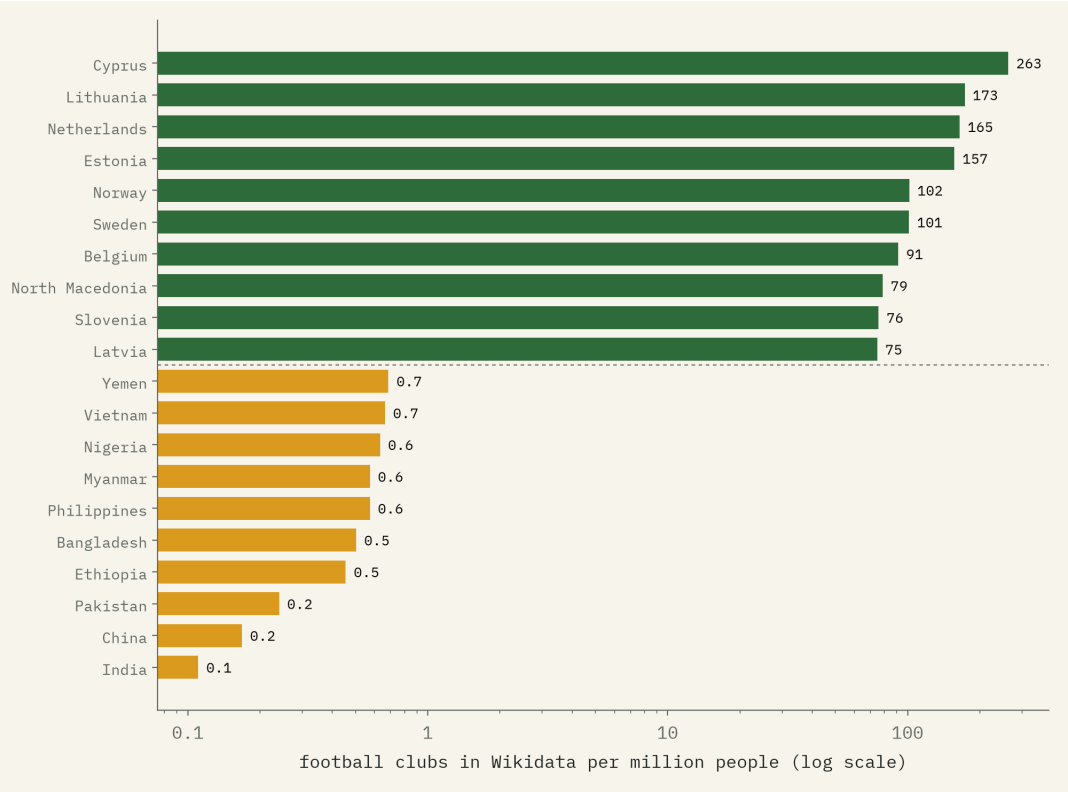


Figure 7: Clubs in Wikidata per million people: the ten highest, and the ten lowest among countries of more than 20 million people.

Table 4: Clubs by continent: share of clubs with a country, and the share of each continent's clubs with a founding year and with a point.

Continent	Clubs	Share	With a year	With a point
Europe	25,560	60.8%	64%	32%
South America	3,403	8.1%	67%	50%
North America	2,989	7.1%	68%	59%
Africa	3,278	7.8%	50%	44%
Asia	6,002	14.3%	59%	44%
Oceania	800	1.9%	75%	47%

4.6 Coverage

Europe holds 61% of clubs with a country, Asia 14% and Africa 8% (Table 4). Per head of population, Wikidata has 165 clubs per million people in the Netherlands and 0.6 in Nigeria (Figure 7); the most catalogued countries per head are small European ones where editors have entered amateur and village clubs systematically. Clubs are thinly described: half have 2 or fewer sitelinks and 44% at most one, and 11,733 have no English label.

5 Discussion

The open record reproduces the broad history of football's spread that historians describe: a dense English and Scottish core in the 1860s and 1870s, early outposts along trade and imperial routes, a European boom after the First World War, and a long second wave across Africa, Asia and the Americas in the second half of the twentieth century. The diffusion front is clearly shaped by sea

routes rather than distance, which fits accounts of football carried by merchants, sailors, engineers and teachers (Goldblatt, 2006), though the data themselves say nothing about who those people were.

The stronger lesson is about the record. The Netherlands has more clubs in Wikidata than Germany, Cyprus more per head than anywhere, and India and China fewer per head than almost anywhere. Those are facts about Wikidata's editors, not about football. First-club years are more robust than counts, since they need only one well-documented old club, but even they depend on someone having entered that club with a date, and some first dates belong to older multi-sport societies.

6 Limitations

First, Wikidata is incomplete and uneven, and the totals count catalogued clubs, not clubs. Second, the definition of a club depends on Wikidata's classes, which mix clubs, teams and sections; my filters are name based and will both miss and wrongly remove some items. Third, a founding year may be that of a parent society, a refounding or a mistake, and dissolution dates are sparse and recent-heavy. Fourth, 3,177 points come from a town in the club's name and are approximate; others come from a club's current ground, which may have moved. Fifth, countries are present-day countries, so a club founded in the Austro-Hungarian empire is counted in today's Czech Republic or Ukraine. Sixth, nothing here identifies founders or their nationality. Finally, all counts are for one retrieval in 2026.

7 Conclusion

A single open query can trace football's spread from Sheffield to 222 countries and territories, show the waves of club founding by decade and continent, and record the clubs that died. It cannot say who founded them, and its gaps are themselves a finding. The atlas maps what is known, shows clearly where little is known, and lets readers explore both.

Data and code availability

The interactive atlas is at https://maps.tristanhotham.com/football-origins/. Data and code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/football-origins and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23844505. Derived data are released under CC BY 4.0 and code under the MIT licence.

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

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